

ALL SHOOK UP
Young agitators in Kathmandu, Sept. 8

anger about corruption and the unholy coalition formed to protect leaders from investigations." The controversy over the platforms merely lit the fuse. In the weeks before the ban, hashtags such as #nepobabies and #nepokids had been trending in Nepal, as citizens contrasted their stagnating lifestyles with the conspicuous consumption of scions of political families who flaunted their Rolex watches and Gucci bags on Instagram posts. For many ordinary Nepalis, by contrast, migration has been the only escape from shrinking domestic opportunities: villages hollowed out, parents distant from children, remittances sustaining consumption but not building capacity.

The major issue Gen Z is facing in Nepal is the mounting economic distress brought on by joblessness, with successive governments failing to address the issue. COVID only exacerbated the unemployment figures and hastened migration to other countries, especially of those under the age of 30, a cohort that accounts for nearly 56 per cent of the country's total population of 29.6 million. While Nepal's overall unemployment rate stood at 10.8 per cent in 2024, it was 20.8 per cent, or nearly double, for the Gen Z age group of 15-24. The lack of job opportunities saw an estimated 4.5 million of Nepalis migrating to other countries like India, the Gulf nations and the Far East for employment. Remittances by Nepalis working abroad, in fact, form the backbone of the domestic economy, accounting for 33 per cent of the GDP, according to the World Bank. Remittance inflows accounted for close to $14 billion in 2024, and nearly 76 per cent of the households were found to rely on them, the remittances often contributing a third to household incomes.

THE SOCIAL MEDIA BAN ONLY LIT THE FUSE. LONG BEFORE IT, HASHTAGS LIKE #NEPOBABIES HAD BEEN TRENDING, CONTRASTING ORDINARY CITIZENS' LIFESTYLE WITH POLITICIANS' KIDS

REVOLVING DOOR GOVERNMENTS

Over the past few decades, Nepali politics had become a game of musical chairs, with power alternating within the old triumvirate of leaders from the three major political parties—Sher Bhahadur Deuba of the Nepali Congress (NC), who was prime minister five times if one includes the days of the monarchy; Pushpa Kumar Dahal (Prachanda) of the Communist Party of Nepal-Maoist Centre or CPN(MC), who was PM four times; and K.P. Sharma Oli, Communist Party of Nepal-Unified Marxist Leninist (CPN-UML), who was serving his fourth term before it was brought to an abrupt end. Though they occupied the central orbit of power till recently, not only was their gravitational pull weakening, their resonance among the youth, too, was waning, as they increasingly appeared to become disconnected with their aspirations. Worse, corruption and nepotism had become endemic, with top leaders accused of being at the heart of the rot.

Moreover, after the abolition of the monarchy in 2008 and a new constitution coming into force in 2015, Nepal has had continuing political instability, with 14 changes in government in the past 17 years. One reason for this endemic instability is Nepal's mixed electoral system, which doesn't readily enable a full majority. Of the 275 seats in the lower house, 165 are filled through a first-past-the-post mechanism like in India, and 110 are filled via proportional representation based on party vote shares. That has seen no major political party cross the simple majority of 138 seats to form a government on its own, resulting in a series of coalition governments.

GENERATION GAP

Compounding the nation's problems is that Nepal's social geography is distributed across three major population groups out of sync with each other. There are the Pahadi (hill-origin caste groups) comprised of the dominant Bahun (Brahmin), Chhetri (Kshatriya) and Thakuri communities, accounting for close to 31 per cent of the population and most of the political elite. Second are the Janajati (Adivasi or indigenous nationalities) spread across the hills and plains who account for another 31 per cent and are often